Trip Planning Checklist

Your pre-trip safety checklist for outdoor adventures in Pierce County, Washington and beyond

Every successful outdoor adventure starts with good planning. As a search and rescue unit responding to emergencies across 1,800 square miles of Pierce County — from sea level on the Puget Sound to the summit of Mt. Rainier — we've seen firsthand how basic preparation prevents the majority of backcountry emergencies.

THE #1 THING YOU CAN DO

Tell someone your plans. Leave a detailed trip plan with a trusted contact who is NOT going with you: where you're going, your route, your vehicle description and where it's parked, and when you expect to return. If you don't check in on time, they should call 911.

Research & Preparation

- ☐ Weather: Check the forecast for your destination AND along your route. Mountain weather in the Cascades can change dramatically with elevation. Pack for the worst realistic conditions.
- ☐ Trail conditions: Check for closures, washouts, snow levels, and recent trip reports. The NPS and WTA websites are good sources for Pierce County trails.
- ☐ Permits: Verify if your destination requires a Discover Pass, National Park pass, or wilderness permit. Some trailheads fill early on weekends.
- ☐ Fitness match: Choose trails and activities that match the LEAST experienced person in your group. Be honest about fitness levels — this isn't the time for ego.
- ☐ Backup plan: Have an alternate destination in case conditions aren't suitable. Knowing when to change plans is a sign of good judgment, not weakness.

Gear & Supplies

- ☐ Ten Essentials: Navigation, sun protection, insulation, illumination, first aid, fire, repair tools, nutrition, hydration, emergency shelter. See our Ten Essentials Guide for details.
- ☐ Extra clothing: Pack layers for conditions 20°F colder than forecast. Hypothermia is possible in any season in the Pacific Northwest mountains.
- ☐ Food and water: Bring more than you think you'll need — at least one extra meal and one extra liter. Your body burns more calories at altitude and in cold.
- ☐ Charged devices: Full charge on your phone, plus a portable battery pack. Download offline maps before you leave cell coverage.
- ☐ Vehicle prep: Full tank of gas, spare tire checked, tow strap, jumper cables, and a blanket in your vehicle.

SAR PRO TIP

Most of the people we rescue planned to be out for 'just a few hours.' Afternoon weather, a wrong turn, or a minor injury can turn a short hike into an overnight. Always pack as if you might have to spend the night out.

Communication Plan

- ☐ Trip plan filed: Give your trusted contact a written plan with your route, timeline, vehicle description (make, model, color, plate number), and where you're parking.
- ☐ Check-in schedule: Set specific check-in times if you'll have cell coverage at any point.
- ☐ Overdue protocol: Tell your contact exactly what to do and when: 'If you haven't heard from me by 8 PM Sunday, call 911 and tell them my trip plan.'
- ☐ Emergency contacts: Save local emergency numbers in your phone. For Pierce County: 911 for emergencies, (253) 798-7530 for non-emergency sheriff.

At the Trailhead

- ☐ Sign in at the trailhead register if one is available
- ☐ Note exactly where you parked and take a photo of your surroundings
- ☐ Confirm your turnaround time with your group — commit to it

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- ☐ Do a final gear check: water, food, layers, navigation, first aid, light source
- ☐ Assess conditions in person — be willing to change plans if something looks wrong

On the Trail

- ☐ Stay on marked trails — going off-trail is the #1 way people get lost
- ☐ Check your map regularly, not just when you think you're lost
- ☐ Set a firm turnaround time and stick to it, even if you haven't reached your destination
- ☐ Monitor weather changes — if conditions deteriorate, head back immediately
- ☐ Pace to the slowest member of your group. Stay together.
- ☐ Drink water and eat snacks regularly — don't wait until you're thirsty or hungry

When You Return

- ☐ Sign out at the trailhead register
- ☐ Notify your emergency contact that you're back safely
- ☐ Report any trail hazards to the land manager (downed trees, washouts, etc.)
- ☐ Restock anything you used from your emergency kit before your next trip

REMEMBER

The backcountry doesn't care about your schedule. Nature sets the rules. The best adventurers are the ones who come home safely every time. When in doubt, turn around. The mountain will be there next weekend.